



The First Thousand

A from-scratch playbook for your first
1,000 followers on X

8 TO 12 WEEKS | 45 TO 60 MINUTES A DAY | NO PAID TOOLS NEEDED

Milestones, checklists, reply templates, a daily card and an 8-week plan.

START HERE

How to use this guide

This is a working playbook, not a reading list. Read Module 1 once, then do the checklists in order. Each module ends with a milestone. Do not move on until you hit it.

Module	Followers	The job	Time
1. How it works	Before you start	Learn the rules of the game	20 min
2. Setup	0	Make your profile a landing page	1 hour
3. Get seen	0 to 100	Reply your way into a small circle	Weeks 1 to 2
4. Give a reason to stay	100 to 500	Four post types, one scoreboard	Weeks 3 to 5
5. Compound	500 to 1,000	Double the winner, kill the rest	Weeks 6 to 8+
6. Operating system	Always	Daily card, weekly review, 8-week plan	Ongoing
7. Dos, don'ts, FAQ	Always	The guardrails	10 min

Be honest about the timeline

Every source behind this guide (listed at the end) agrees on the shape: a clean profile, daily useful replies to people your own size, and a few original posts a week that each do one job. They disagree on speed. Screenshots of 0 to 700 followers in four days almost always hide something: an existing audience, six-hour days, or a much bigger main account. Plan for 8 to 12 weeks at about an hour a day. Faster is possible. It is not the baseline.

What you need

- A real X account and about 45 to 60 minutes a day for 8 to 12 weeks.
- One topic you can talk about for a year without getting bored.
- A notes app or spreadsheet for your account list and weekly numbers.
- X Premium is optional. It helps a little. It does not replace the steps below.

MODULE 1

How X growth actually works

Four ideas. If you only remember these, you will already beat most people who post daily and stay stuck.

Milestone

You can explain, in your own words, why a small account can beat a large one on a given day.

1. The feed tests every post on its own

X does not broadcast your post to your followers and hope. It shows the post to a small group, watches what they do, and only widens the audience if the reaction is good. Follower count is a weak starting point, not a guarantee. This is why a 200-follower account can outperform a 20,000-follower account on a given day, and why 12 views on a post is not proof the algorithm hates you. It means the post did not earn the next circle.

2. Replies and profile actions beat likes

You will see tables claiming a reply is worth a fixed multiple of a like. Those numbers come from an older ranking system and have shifted. What has held up: the system rewards replies, profile clicks, follows, time spent reading and shares far more than likes. Public weights from one 2026 release put copy-link shares and author replies to mutual followers highest, then replies, then follows, with likes near the bottom. Treat any exact number as a snapshot and check the source before quoting it. Write for conversation and for the profile click, not for the heart.

3. Two currencies: reach and gravity

Currency	What it is	What you track weekly
Reach	Strangers seeing you	Impressions on replies and posts
Gravity	People who come back, reply, visit your profile and remember you	Profile visits, new follows, people who reply to you twice

Followers are a lagging scoreboard. If reach is up and gravity is flat, your profile or pinned post is not converting. If gravity is fine and reach is dead, you keep talking to the same eleven people and need a wider circle.

4. Your friend network is a ranking input

A post first goes to circle one, the people who already talk to you. If they reply, or you reply back, the post is allowed to reach circle two, strangers the model is willing to test. A banger with no circle one never leaves the room, and an account with no history of talking to anyone launches like a brand-new one even at a few thousand followers. So your first job is not a perfect post. It is 20 to 40 people who know your name. After you publish, stay with the post for 30 to 40 minutes and answer every useful comment.

The ladder

Stage	Job	Where people fail
0 to 100	Get seen. Make friends.	Posting into a void, or replying to huge accounts that will never notice you
100 to 1,000	Give people a reason to stay	No point of view, all tips, no proof
1,000 to 10,000	Go viral on purpose	Random posting, no kill list, no timing
10,000+	Become a brand	Inconsistent opinions, protecting ego over the brand

This guide covers the first two rows. Do not run stage 3 tactics before people reply to you.

MODULE 2

Set up your profile in one hour

Your profile is the landing page every reply sends people to. If a stranger cannot tell what you do in two seconds, they leave.

Milestone

Profile complete, pinned post live, account list started. Then stop tinkering.

Profile checklist

- ☐ Profile photo is a clear, recognizable face (or a consistent logo if you must). Keep it for 90 days.
- ☐ Header image is simple and readable on mobile. No collage.
- ☐ Display name is your real name or the name you will use for years.
- ☐ Bio is one sentence that says what you do and who it is for (formula below).
- ☐ Five-second test done: two people in your niche saw the profile for five seconds and could say what you tweet about and why to follow. "Startups" or "AI" means the page failed.
- ☐ One line under the bio states your public goal or your proof.
- ☐ Link points to one page: your product, newsletter or portfolio. Not a link tree.
- ☐ Pinned post written and pinned (template below).
- ☐ Notifications on for the 5 accounts you plan to reply to first.
- ☐ New or dormant account? Read the warm-up box before you start replying in volume.

Bio formulas

I help [who] do [what] without [pain].
Building [thing]. Notes on [topic] for [audience].
[Credential or proof]. Now: [what you are doing publicly].

Keep it to one job. Works: "I design billing for SaaS teams. Building the v1 in public. 90 days to the first paying customer." Fails: "Founder | AI | Web3 | Sharing my journey. Open to collab." It names no job, no time box and no reason to come back. At low follower counts a visible goal earns more follows than a credential, because it gives people a story to follow.

Pinned post template

I'm at [N] followers. Goal: 1,000 by [date].

I'm running this as a public experiment because [reason you care].

What you'll see here:

- one [explainer / breakdown] a week on [topic]
- the boring numbers behind the growth, every Friday
- what I tried, what died, what worked

Week 1 numbers go in the replies.

Warm-up for new accounts

Brand-new account, or one that has been dormant for a long time? Expect limited reach for the first weeks. Ramp replies gradually (10 a day, then 20, then more), avoid links and identical copy-paste replies, and do not follow or unfollow in bulk. Aggressive behavior early is the fastest way to get throttled. An older account with a normal history has an advantage. Use it.

MODULE 3

0 to 100: get seen

Nobody finds you by accident at this size. You go to where a few people are already paying attention and add something worth reading.

Milestone

100 followers, 10 people who have replied to you more than once, and 5 days in a row of the daily reply routine.

Build your bubble first

Make a note with 40 accounts in three columns. Refresh it every Sunday.

Column	Who	Why
A. Peers (25)	150 to 2,500 followers, same topic, still posting daily	They notice a good reply. This is your first real audience.
B. Borrow reach (10)	5k to 80k followers in your niche	Their comment sections are busy. A sharp reply in the first 15 minutes gets seen by their readers.
C. Repeat 15	Anyone who replies back to you	Start empty. Protect it. Talk to them weekly.

Two things to expect

Early posts get 8 to 40 views. That is normal and not a verdict on quality. Growth at this stage comes from replies that earn profile visits. Skip "drop your handle" connect threads: they inflate the badge but the followers are not in your niche, and they do not count toward the milestone.

Where to find peers: open the replies under posts from bigger accounts in your niche and look at the repliers, not the original poster. Search phrases your audience uses ("just launched", "building in public", "day 30") and read who is answering.

The 70/30 rule

Split your effort about 70 percent peers and 30 percent bigger accounts. Some guides say never reply to big accounts, others say only reply to big accounts. Both are half right. Peers build your friend network. Bigger accounts borrow reach. You need both.

The reply test

Could this reply be screenshotted and stand as its own post? If not, delete it.

"Great post!" and "Rooting for you" get a few views and no profile clicks. A useful reply adds something the author does not have: a number, a contrary cut, a short story or a sharp question.

Four reply shapes

Shape	Template	Use when
Number + condition	"This works until roughly [N]. After that [what changes], so [what to do instead]."	You have a real data point
Specific add	"The part people skip: [missing step]. Without it, [consequence]."	The post is right but incomplete
Mini-story	"[Time] doing [thing]. First attempt: [result]. What changed: [one lesson]."	You have lived it
Extending question	"Would this still hold if [edge case]? That is the version I'd want to see."	You want the author to reply

Before and after

Weak	Stronger
"Love this, following your journey!"	"Ten years in a corporate job where marketing was someone else's problem. First month doing it myself, every post that listed features died and the one explainer did not. Curious how you sequenced the story."
"Good point about ICPs."	"An ICP that lives in a doc and never reaches 20 outbound messages is how founders stall for a quarter. One sentence plus real conversations beats another positioning exercise."

Daily reply routine (30 minutes)

Daily routine
☐ Block 1, 15 minutes: 8 to 10 replies to peers on posts under 3 hours old.
☐ Block 2, 15 minutes: 5 to 8 replies to bigger niche accounts, ideally within 15 minutes of their post.
☐ First 3 replies of the day go to your Repeat 15 (Column C).
☐ If an author replies, answer within 30 minutes. That exchange is worth more than 20 cold replies.
☐ Never drop a link in a reply unless asked.
☐ Cap at the number you can write well. 15 to 25 good replies beat 80 empty ones.
☐ Log it: date, account, shape used, did the author reply, profile visits that day.

Match the blocks to when your audience is awake, not to your own schedule. If most of your niche is in the US and you are elsewhere, your best reply window is their morning, which may be your evening.

Module 3 milestone checklist
☐ 40-account list built (25 peers, 10 borrow-reach, Repeat 15 started).
☐ Pinned post live and profile complete.
☐ Five consecutive days of the reply routine.
☐ 10 authors have replied to you at least once.
☐ You have followed people who replied to you and know why you followed each one.
☐ Followers: 100.

MODULE 4

100 to 500: give people a reason to stay

Replies bring strangers to your profile. Posts decide whether they follow. Every original post gets exactly one job.

Milestone

500 followers, one repeatable weekly format that clearly outperforms the rest, and 15 named people in your Repeat list.

The four post jobs

Aim for 4 to 6 original posts a week. If a post tries to do two jobs, split it into two.

Job	Frequency	What it does	Shape
A. Explainer	1 per week	Proves you know something. This is what gets bookmarked.	A clear breakdown of one idea, one screenshot or diagram, long enough to save.
B. Scoreboard	1 per week, same day	Gives people a story to follow and a reason to check back.	Week N. Followers X to Y. What worked. What I killed. What I'm doubling.
C. Proof	1 to 2 per week	Shows results instead of claiming them.	One real screenshot plus one sentence about who it helped.
D. Opinion	1 per week	Something a mid-size account could quote without you.	One sharp sentence, no hashtags, no thread.

Scoreboard template (post it every Friday)

Week [N]. Followers: [start] to [end].

Profile visits: [x]

Replies written: [x]

Authors who replied back: [x]

Killed this week: [format or habit]

Doubling next week: [format or habit]

It will feel awkward at 130 followers. That is the point. It is the post that makes the right 40 people come back next week.

Kill list for originals

- Changelogs and feature lists. Nobody outside the room cares.
- "Excited to announce." Announcements are for lists you already have.
- Raw chatbot output. The cadence shows.
- Off-niche hot takes and quote-dunks. You train a graph you do not want.

Weekly mix: two explainers, one scoreboard, one proof, one opinion. With only three slots, drop the opinion first, never the scoreboard. An opinion should be narrow enough to be wrong: "distribution matters" cannot be argued with, and that is why it does not travel.

Story shapes that hold attention

- The bet: what you are trying, the number, the deadline.
- The journey with a number: "Day 40. 212 followers. Here is what moved."

- The failure: what did not work and what you changed. Be vulnerable without losing credibility. Share the lesson, not the meltdown.
- The transformation: then versus now, with the ugly middle left in.

Content mix

Type	Share	Notes
Entertaining	40%	Hooks, humor, relatable moments
Educational	30%	Explainers and breakdowns
Inspirational	20%	Stories, milestones, lessons
Selling	10%	Only after the story has earned it

Treat this as a starting ratio, not a law. Let your numbers overrule it.

Module 4 milestone checklist
☐ Every original post this week had one job and passed a 5-second test: could a stranger tell what it is?
☐ Scoreboard posted on the same day for 3 weeks in a row.
☐ You know which of the four jobs produced the most follows.
☐ You killed at least one format that consistently died.
☐ Repeat 15 list has 15 real names.
☐ Followers: 500.

MODULE 5

500 to 1,000: double the winner

By now the data can tell you something. Stop guessing, keep what works, cut the rest.

Milestone

1,000 followers with the four proof points in the last section, not just the number.

Read the numbers weekly

Every post is a test of format, angle and topic. When one works, run it again with a new example instead of inventing something new. Changing too fast throws away the momentum you just built. Most people only ever add things. Operators subtract.

Build a kill list

Write down every format or habit that had a fair shot and died. Keep it visible when you open the compose box. Typical entries:

- Feature-list posts ("shipped 8 things")
- Generic cheerleading replies
- Quote-tweets of big accounts with nothing added
- Vague questions with no stake
- Tool or link spam
- Anything you posted only because you had to post

Format rules for 500 and up

- Do not reinvent yourself at 500. The room finally knows what you are. Swapping persona around 780 is how momentum dies.
- Three strikes and a format is dead. Change the metric, not the persona: if explainers stall, shorten them before you start a newsletter.
- Around 600 you are a peer. Stop introductions and "new here" posts, and write like one.
- Keep politics, celebrity takes and dating posts out. Each invites a room that will not help your next explainer.
- Never let replies lapse. Accounts that swap the reply block for threads tend to stall in the 300s.

Ride one wave at a time

Do not invent a conversation. Enter one that is already happening in your niche (a launch, a news event, a platform change) with a specific take, a small demo or a number, and your own story attached. One well-timed post can bring more followers than a month of average ones.

Do one collaboration

By week 6, find someone at a similar or slightly larger size and do something together: a reply chain, a joint breakdown, or a quote post with a real add. Two audiences overlapping is worth more than doubling your own posts.

Video is optional at this stage

Video matters more from 1k to 10k. Below that, a tight written explainer with a screenshot often beats an average video. If you do make video, keep it raw, lead with the point in the first two seconds, and keep it short. Do not stall on this if the fear of being on camera is the blocker. Written posts will carry you to 1,000.

If you stall

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
Reach is up, follows are flat	Profile or pin is not converting	Rewrite the pin and the bio line; check that the last 6 posts look like the pin
Follows are okay, reach is dead	You are talking to the same few people	Add 10 new peers and 5 new borrow-reach accounts
Neither moves	Replies are too generic	Re-read the reply test; cut volume and raise quality
Missed the weekly number by 30% or more	Not a posting problem	Audit replies: wrong accounts, too slow, or too vague. Do not just post more
Stuck at 850 to 950	Normal plateau	Do not panic-post. Run one more cycle of the same plan

Do not shortcut the last stretch

Do not buy followers, join follow-back pods or use auto-follow tools to hit the number. A graph full of mutual-follow ghosts makes 1,000 to 3,000 much harder than 0 to 1,000 was.

MODULE 6

The operating system

This module is the part you print. Everything here is meant to be used, not read.

Milestone

You run the daily card for 14 days without skipping more than one.

Daily card

DATE: _____
 BLOCK 1 (15 min): __ peer replies author replied back: __
 BLOCK 2 (15 min): __ reach replies author replied back: __
 ORIGINAL TODAY: [] explainer [] scoreboard [] proof [] opinion [] none
 FOLLOWERS start / end: ____ / ____
 PROFILE VISITS: ____
 ONE THING I'LL REUSE TOMORROW: _____
 ONE THING I KILL: _____

Daily blocks

Block	Time	Output	Skip rule
Write	15 to 20 min	One original, or none	Skip if it maps to no job
Peer replies	15 min	8 to 12 to Columns A and C	Never skip
Reach replies	15 min	5 to 8 to Column B, each with an add	Skip if you would only cheerlead
Answer	5 to 10 min	Every useful comment	Never skip

Only 30 minutes? Cut Write, keep Peers and Answer. Put the block on your calendar as "A/C block", not "content". Friday's Write slot is the scoreboard. Sunday is review only.

The X log, five lines a day

- Date and minutes actually spent.
- Replies that passed the standalone test.
- Authors who answered.
- Original shipped (job name) or none.
- Profile visits and follows from analytics.

The five weekly numbers

Followers, impressions, profile visits, replies written, and authors who replied back. The last one is the most important. It is the closest thing to a leading indicator you have.

Sunday review (20 minutes)

- ☐ Drop 10 dead accounts from your list, add 10 new ones.
- ☐ Circle the 3 replies that got author responses. Copy their shape next week.
- ☐ Write down one format to kill and one to double.
- ☐ Draft Friday's scoreboard numbers while the week is fresh.

8-week plan

Week	Followers	Pass or fail
1	0 to 40	Fail if fewer than 8 authors reply back
2	40 to 90	Fail if profile visits are unreadable
3	90 to 160	Name 10 repeat humans or repeat the week
4	160 to 250	Say which post job produced follows
5	250 to 380	Under 220 means replies are the bottleneck
6	380 to 550	One peer conversation visible in public
7	550 to 780	Ride one live wave with an add, or log why you skipped
8	780 to 1,000	No new formats. Count unprompted repliers

Follower ranges are weather; the pass or fail line is law. Fail a week and you repeat it. Targets assume about 10 hours a week, and at 4 hours expect 12 to 16 weeks. Growth is lumpy: one good week often equals three average ones. Judge yourself on the process numbers, not a single week.

MODULE 7

Dos, don'ts and FAQ

Keep this page open while you work.

Milestone

You can name your top three habits to keep and your top three to stop.

DO	DON'T
Reply with something that could stand alone as a post.	Post feature lists or changelogs as your main content.
Spend most reply time on peers within 10x of your size.	Reply "great post" or "rooting for you".
Answer anyone who replies to you, fast.	Spend all your time under celebrity accounts.
Keep the same photo and name for 90 days.	Use follow-for-follow as your pitch or run pods.
Post the scoreboard on the same day every week.	Change your niche every two weeks.
Show real screenshots and real numbers.	Start with threads and long videos before you have a circle.
Kill formats that have had a fair chance and died.	Put links in replies or in the main post unless asked.
Enter conversations already happening in your niche.	Post the same reply to many people.
Follow back people you have actually exchanged replies with.	Compare your week 3 to someone else's year 3.

Myths, corrected

Common claim	What holds up
"Never reply to big accounts."	Half true. Use them for borrowed reach, in the first 15 minutes, with a real add. Keep peers as the main effort.
"50 to 100 replies a day."	Fine for a short sprint. Not a lifestyle. Quality falls and empty replies get ignored.
"Follow-for-follow is trash."	Blind F4F is. Following back people you have exchanged real replies with is how most early growth actually happens.
"You must do video in 2026."	It matters more later. A strong written explainer beats a mediocre video at this size.
"Just be consistent."	Only if you also cut what does not work. Consistency on the wrong format keeps you stuck.
"Someone grew 0 to 200 in two days."	Usually with an existing audience or hours of daily replying. Do not use it to forecast yourself.

Looks like work, isn't

Looks like work	Do this instead
Redesigning the banner	Five-second bio test with a human
Planning 30 content pillars	Pick one job for 90 days
Reading 12 growth threads	Do the reply drill
Building a scheduling stack	A calendar event named A/C block
Warm-up tools for a new account	Rewrite the old account

FAQ

How many posts a day?

At this stage, replies matter more than posts. 4 to 6 original posts a week is enough. Do not chase volume.

Should I use hashtags?

No. They add nothing at this size and make posts look like ads.

Do I need Premium?

It gives a small boost and is not required. Do the profile and reply work first.

What if nobody replies to my replies?

Reply quality or target is off. Move to accounts with fewer followers, aim for posts under 3 hours old, and add a number or a story.

What if I am shy about sharing numbers?

Start with process numbers (replies written, visits) rather than revenue. The scoreboard works even when the numbers are small.

Can I schedule posts?

Yes for planned posts. Reply live. Replies to fresh posts are where the value is.

FINISH LINE

What 1,000 should mean

The number is a label. The evidence that you actually have an audience is below. Hit these before you celebrate.

The real milestone
☐ 20 people reply to you without you prompting them.
☐ Your weekly explainer clears 1,000 views without luck or a boost.
☐ Profile visits do not collapse when you skip a day.
☐ You can name your Repeat 15 from memory.
☐ You know your kill list and your winning format.
☐ You have a public goal for the next stage.

Your first 7 days, in order

Day	Do this
1	Profile and bio done. Write and pin the goal post. Build the 40-account list. Turn on notifications for 5 accounts. Send 10 peer replies.
2	15 replies. Draft your first explainer from something you already know.
3	15 replies. Publish the explainer. Reply to everyone who responds.
4	15 replies. Post one proof piece: a screenshot of something real.
5	15 replies. Post one sharp opinion. Post the first scoreboard, even if the numbers are tiny.
6	15 replies. Rest from original posts.
7	20-minute review: refresh the list, circle the replies that worked, choose one thing to kill.

Show up, be useful to specific people, keep score, and cut what does not work. It is unglamorous. It is also what nearly every from-scratch story in the sources below has in common.

Where this comes from

This guide synthesizes public playbooks and case studies from operators who grew accounts from a small base. None of them is a guarantee, and they disagree on pace. What they agree on is what this guide keeps.

Source	What survived	What was dropped
Rob Hallam (@robj3d3)	Per-post test, profile as landing page, story spine, make-friends framing	Two-day throwaway account as a forecast
Daniel Smidstrup, ClimbX	Reply block on the calendar, a journey people can follow, weekly review	50 to 100 replies a day as a default
Luckforest (@lubinho_k)	Same-size tribe, milestone posts. 1,000 took 8 months and about 3,800 posts	Chasing heroes
Nikita Bier's 2022 ladder	Energy changes with size: replies first, niche posts after 500	Rungs meant for other kinds of accounts
Phoenix For You, open-sourced Aug 2026	The shape: conversation and shares beat likes	Exact weights as law; they change

The full course, with the source posts embedded, is at first-thousand.pages.dev.

Excluded on purpose: auto-follow farms, pods, and any method that depends on fake engagement. Platform behavior changes. Re-check any specific ranking claim before you build a strategy on it.